

An Undergraduate Brother's Perspective

What Advice Would You Give for Initiation Ritual?

By Michael Stirm (St. Joseph's 2009)

Editor's Note: Brother Michael Stirm (St. Joseph's 2009) is a senior and English major at St. Joseph's University. He recently researched and presented the following speech to his chapter and associate members during pre-initiation last fall. As we celebrate our Centennial, Stirm's undergraduate perspective on our Initiation Ritual is a fitting tribute to our 100-year milestone.

What Advice Would You Give for Initiation Ritual?

Every semester you ask the same question. And every semester your chapter High Kappa recommends that you ask it. It is guaranteed to crop up, in some form or another, in so many words, and like clockwork, it is asked. The answers you will get vary from brother to brother and his answer reveals how he understands and appreciates our Initiation Ritual.

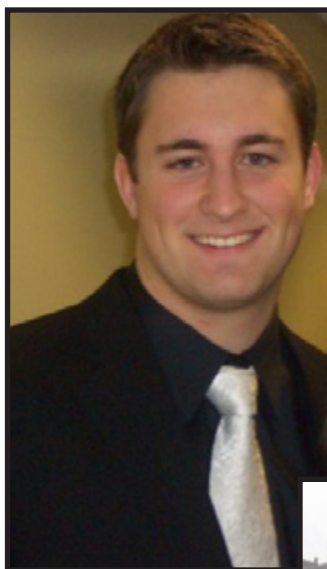
I am here to tell you that our Initiation Ritual is an important, possibly life-changing event that has been passed down to us by one of its biggest authors, John Mason (Pennsylvania 1913).

Brother Mason spent years in libraries, both in America and Europe, studying the rituals of history, rituals of the Knights Templar, the Freemasons, and societies more ancient than these. His years of research produced a beautiful and humbling work of art in the form of our Initiation Ritual.

Before I give you my advice for our Initiation Ritual, I want to share with you some of the things I've learned along the way to understanding ritual as an ancient and valuable form of transmitting information and elevating the mind.

Freemason Perspective

Most of this information comes from a book called *Turning the Hiram Key*, written by Robert Lomas, a Freemason and the real-life inspiration for Dan Brown's character, Robert Langdon.



The book basically investigates ritual as an ancient spiritual practice, and specifically, how it relates to the secret society of Freemasons. Human ritual has two characteristics:

1. It generates emotional discharges in varying degrees of intensity that represent subjective feelings of tranquility, ecstasy, and awe; and,
2. It results in mental states that are often explained as some degree of spiritual transcendence. The cognitive setting (your state of mind) in which ritual is carried out has a direct emotional impact on the participant's brain.

"The story-telling sense of the myth combines with emotional arousal effects to produce a powerful means of imparting information. You often feel that you have had a close encounter with the source of order in the universe."

After consulting numerous experts on the craft, Lomas comes to understand that the purpose of Freemasonic Ritual is to pass from mere manhood and carnal understanding to "conscious Godhood whilst we are still in the flesh." It is "the realization of our fundamental unity and identity with the ultimate of ultimates, a world-old science

taught and practiced in secret by the few spiritually ripe and courageous enough for following a higher path of life."

In the book, Lomas presents information from medical experts who have found that "spiritual practices such as meditation, prayer, and taking part in ritual services reduces feelings of anxiety and depression, boosts self-esteem, and often results in a more positive approach to life."



Keep these things in mind as you approach the end of this week and the Initiation Ritual. I wish that I had had this information in my head before ritual because I really feel like it would have made a difference in the way I experienced it.

On You, In You, Through You

My advice to you is do not try to understand it. You will not understand its meaning immediately. I'm sure there are brothers who still don't really understand it in the way it is meant to be understood. What you can do is pay attention to everything you're seeing and hearing as it takes place. Allow the Initiation Ritual to act on you, in you, and through you. Put yourself completely in the moment. Then afterward, take time to reflect and meditate on what you experienced. What was said, what you saw, etc...It may help to reflect back on the events leading up to the Initiation Ritual and gradually connections will arise and you will understand the meaning and purpose of events in relation to preparation.

But, remember that the events of the associate member process pale in comparison to the truths that are revealed in the actual Initiation Ritual. Every ritual contains truths needing to be extracted from it, "like poetry or music from the printed page, by personal effort, and which can be recognized as truths only by the responsiveness of the soul after deeply meditating and assimilating them."

Our Initiation Ritual is no less complex and esoteric than the ritual of the Freemasons. Esoteric comes from the Greek word "esotero" meaning further-in. Plato's teachings were given only to relatively advanced people who had gained admission to Plato's inner-circle as a result of intense intellectual study and preparation.

The purpose of the past weeks was not to turn each of you into a walking Paedagogus, but to mold and transform you mentally, spiritually, and emotionally and to prepare you for your commencement as brothers of Lambda Chi Alpha. What you have been doing, hopefully, is growing.

Guestbook & Merchandise

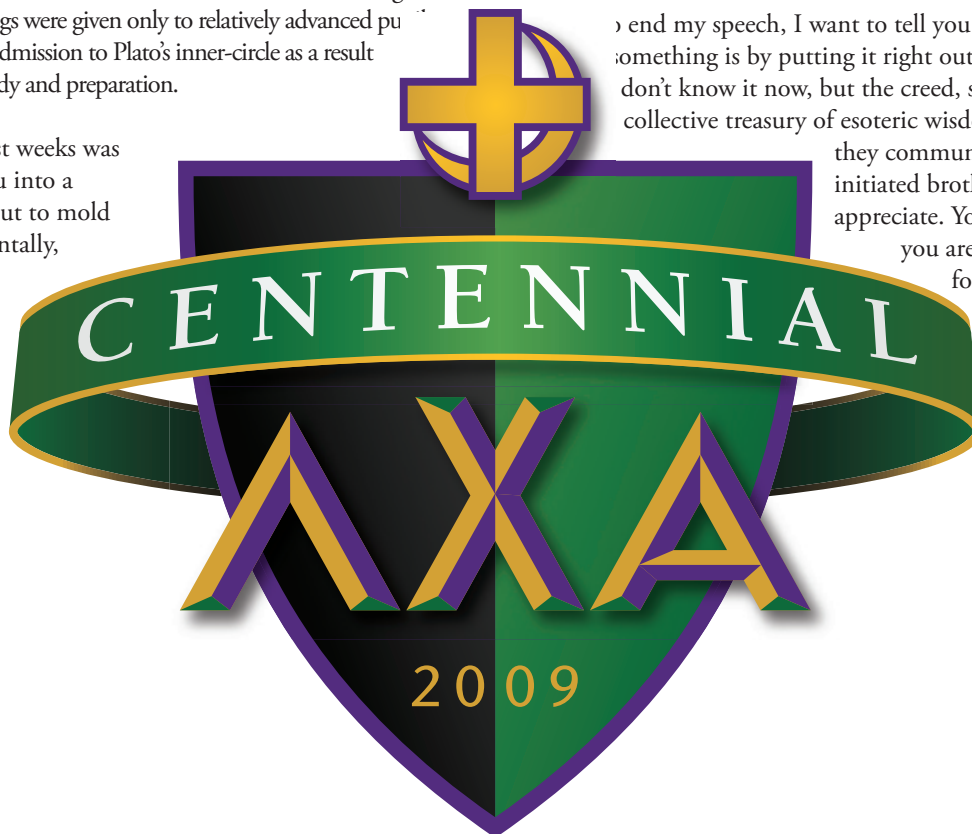
The communications staff at the International Headquarters staff has added Centennial Guestbook and Centennial Merchandise pages to our website. We encourage you to access both of these new areas to both tell us your most memorable moments of our first century, as well as to order some the new promotional and clothing items.

The crescent is our symbol, pure, high and always growing, ever-improving towards moral, spiritual, and intellectual wholeness. Remember that.

Growth and Sacrifice

In connection with this ideal, remember the Jesuit idea of the Magis, which in Latin means "the more." It is derived from the word majorum from the Jesuit motto Ad majorum Dei gloriam which means "for the greater glory of God." Everything you do in life should be for God's greater glory, in the crescent and the cross. I don't think I'm giving away any secrets when I tell you that these symbols represent growth and sacrifice, aspiration and humility.

By the end of my speech, I want to tell you that the best way of hiding something is by putting it right out in the open. You guys don't know it now, but the creed, symbols, and mottoes are a collective treasury of esoteric wisdom and knowledge and they communicate meanings that only initiated brothers will recognize and appreciate. You are all blind now. But you are ripe for illumination, ripe for an awakening. You have to have eyes to see. Maybe by the end of this week your eyes, hearts, and minds will be opened to all that Lambda Chi Alpha has to offer. ➕



A CENTURY OF TRUE BROTHERHOOD